

SILENCE OF THE LAMBS

The voice of the moderate Muslim is rarely heard when the community comes under intense pressure

■ By Shafi Rahman

After the serial blasts in Delhi, Jamaat-e-Islami Hind was one of the first Muslim groups to speak out in public. It represents just a fraction of Indian Muslims, yet carries a venomous and divisive political agenda, contests many of the Sufi traditions in the country and once breast-fed Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI) as its unofficial student wing and abandoned it only after finding the Frankenstein too hot to handle. The Jamaat-e-Islami Hind and numerous other fringe organisations—calling themselves Coordination Committee of Indian Muslims—have made a public show of Muslim grievances. “We’re against terrorism but we are also against Batla House-style killings,” they told a thicket of television microphones. It’s a position they have hijacked from the silent majority.

Condemning terror and questioning the version of events put out by the Delhi Police’s Special Cell should ideally come from the moderate liberal voices in the community. But are they speaking out on behalf of the community or just not being heard? “The political leadership in the country never let the moderate Muslim leadership to grow. History shows that no such attempts have ever been made in Independent India,” says political scientist Imtiaz Ahmed.

History is right. During the 1960s, much of the Muslim voice was vented through prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru. “By 1972, there were no Muslim leaders from the liberal elite in the government, except the likes of Ghani Khan Chowdhury,” says Ahmed. In the late ’80s, while moderate Muslim intellectuals from the community expended energy on Urdu revival and personal law, a more street-smart leadership with vote garnering skills began to occupy the political space. “Since they got incorporated into

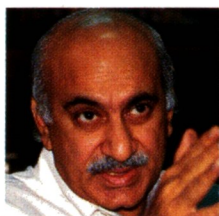


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party structure, their capacity to talk on behalf of Muslims got heightened,” says Ahmed.

A close look at the present Congress leadership would explain the crisis. Jaffer Sharief, who went on to become Union minister, started off as an attendant in the Congress office in Bangalore. Ahmed Patel, powerful political secretary to Congress chief Sonia Gandhi, is known more for his ability to garner numbers during trust votes than articulating minority assimilation and grievances. Muslims are stuck on one side with a band of self-serving leaders ostensibly speaking on

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M. J. AKBAR, JOURNALIST AND AUTHOR